

After songs, the next-most stored type of file on home computers must be image files. And the number of image files on computers is growing, thanks to everyone becoming amateur photographers with digicams. How many of these photos are perfect? Yes, we agree that digitally touching up an image mars its sanctity, especially if it is a memorable one. But what about those wallpaper shots you took that are *almost* perfect, but which can be helped with a little bit of touch-up work? And what about that really huge 5 MB image file that you got at maximum resolution from a digicam that you want to save at a smaller size and resolution?

We will introduce The GIMP to help you with all the above. The GIMP interface is the same on Windows and Linux. You can therefore use this guide even when you are trying The GIMP on Windows.

When you open The GIMP, you will find two windows, one titled “Layers, Channels, Pixels, Undo...”, and the other which simply says “The GIMP.” To open an existing image, go to “The GIMP” window, and as usual, click **File > Open**. Once the file is open, you will see the various options in the image window. At the bottom left of the screen, you can select the zoom level. There are well-thought-of zoom levels from 12% to 800%, but unfortunately, you cannot specify intermediate values. Right next to the zoom control is the unit preference, where you can select the unit shown on the scale—pixels, millimetres, centimetres, inches, and up to metres!

In theory, The GIMP is able to handle such large images. As a first-timer to the software, you can simply open a sample image, click on every menu and see what it contains. Don’t be overwhelmed—just play some soft music in the background and take your time exploring the software. While this is a hard way to learn, we can make life simpler for you (as usual!) and guide you through doing simple image manipulations.